Spotlight: News On Air

Discussion: UPSC at 100 - A Century of Merit, Integrity, and Public Service

Total Words Count: ~1,720 words

Introduction & Centenary Celebrations

Akashvani: This is Akashvani. In the program Spotlight, now we bring a discussion on UPSC at 100: a century of merit, integrity, and public service. The participants are Lt. General Raj Shukla, Member UPSC, and Niharika Bummania, anchor. Today's conversation is centered around the centenary celebrations of the Union Public Service Commission. The celebrations lasted for two entire days, beginning on September 30th and today on October 1st.

The first day featured the Shatabdi Samaroh Manthan at Bharat Mandapam and witnessed addresses by eminent speakers followed by panel discussions on various themes. In fact, on the occasion, the honorable Prime Minister released a UPSC centenary commemorative coin, a stamp, and a book titled "100 Landmark Judgments Shaping the Policies of UPSC and Public Service Commissions in India." And on the occasion, we have Lt. General Raj Shukla, Member UPSC, gracing the studios.

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla: It's a great pleasure joining you. I look forward to the program.

Niharika Bummania: So today was the Shatabdi Samaroh Manthan at Bharat Mandapam, which witnessed a lot of addresses by eminent speakers followed by panel discussions from people from state public service commissions, senior officers of the government, academicians, and UPSC officials. Do you want to share some key takeaways from today's program for our citizens and also for aspiring officers who may be listening to us?

The Foundation and Constitutional Trust

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla: Yeah, so the Union Public Service Commission, as you said, is in the midst of its centenary celebrations. Yesterday we had the chairman giving a long address spelling out the achievements of UPSC and how it intends to address the future. And today's highlight was, of course, the honorable Prime Minister who addressed the gathering. I would strongly urge your viewers to listen to both addresses. They are very thoughtful and will capture for you the entire ethos and spirit of the Union Public Service Commission.

I will just pull out some of the key issues. One is, when it was being debated in the constituent assembly as to what form the UPSC should take, some members were of the view that we should not continue with the UPSC. And then somebody said that in a nation where jobs are given by acquaintance or 'sifarish'—you know, my father, when he joined the Air Force, he used to tell me that having passed the exam he had to return to Lucknow to get a letter of recommendation. Ultimately, a decision was taken to continue with the UPSC so that people get a level playing field.

You don't need a sifarish. You can be from a small town in Ballia; you can be from Delhi. It's a level playing

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla (Cont'd): As the chairman was saying yesterday, this phrase stuck in my mind: the most accurate description of these 100 years is that this has been a century of trust. Many civil servants will tell you that it's a temple. That is the lofty role of the UPSC. Today is a momentous milestone, and therefore we should do three things: celebrate, **introspect** on what we have done right and where we could do better, and crystal gaze—because what **attributes** do we need in the civil servants of the future?

Growth, Equity, and the Scope of Examinations

See how the scale and scope of the UPSC have grown. In 1950, there used to be 42,000 odd applicants for all the services. Today the figure is 41 lakhs, and each demands the highest standards. You have to ensure fairness, **meritocracy**, and **impartiality**. Look at gender **equity**: in 1952, there were three female candidates selected. In 2025, there were 295 selected on their merit, and in the top 25, there were 11 women candidates. This gives you a measure of the grinding, **diligent** work the UPSC has done bit by bit.

You can speak in Hindi, Tamil, or English; all that doesn't matter anymore. It's your intelligence which comes through. We look 1.5 years ahead for our pressing schedule of exams, because in our country, exam **certainty** is very important. If you shift a date, there are **logistics** issues with rentals and psychological impacts on students.

Niharika Bummania: So it looks like it's a body that not only conducts examinations but is also responsible for the larger health of the civil service in terms of disciplinary cases, promotion boards, and a range of disciplines.

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla: Everything else is specialized, but here you interview candidates for engineering, geotechnologies, medicine, defense, and water resources. It's an extraordinary range of disciplines. Yesterday's panels aimed to introspect. I chaired a panel on innovation. We said that we have to move from risk **mitigation** to risk-taking. Innovation disrupts the past. These are not easy things to do, so we look for their sense of judgment in challenging times.

Niharika Bummania: Perhaps **discernment** would be a better word.

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla: Yeah, perhaps discernment, judgment, and decision-making in **ambiguity**. There are no right or wrongs now, or true and false. It's a very complex world.

Global Comparisons and the Modern Civil Servant

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla (Cont'd): There's an interesting case that China is getting ahead because it is an engineering society with a lot of **precision**, whereas America has tended to lag because there are too many lawyers putting rules and regulations in the way. Europe has killed itself by regulation. In our case, the civil servants are the instrument of delivery everywhere.

For example, the Defense Secretary today is a civil servant, but he has to be updated on defense, military, national security, missiles, and air defense. Since they are the instruments of delivery, selecting them is a pretty **onerous** task, but one that is extremely critical to the future of India.

The Prime Minister said the expectations are growing. The citizen is God—they are demanding and ambitious. So there are very complex challenges because the world is changing rapidly. If we aspire to a Viksit, Sudridh, Surakshit Bharat, the **beneficiaries** and architects of this future are these men and women who get selected.

Niharika Bummania: The UPSC has its origins in 1926. The Prime Minister acknowledged it as the steel frame needed for reconstruction. How has it transformed to fulfill the aspirations of an independent nation?

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla: We keep taking steps. We have started Pratibhasha, where names not making the final merit list are available for other government organizations to tap into. A lot of technology is being used for face recognition to make schedules more rigorous. India is now in the big league, just behind China and the United States. The civil servants have to step up the game in international competition.

As the chairman said, we must change that which must change (technology, global best practices) in order that which must never change (trust, faith, integrity) can be preserved.

Looking Forward to Viksit Bharat

Niharika Bummania: What role do you see UPSC playing in Viksit Bharat?

Lt. Gen. Raj Shukla: We have to raise our per capita income by an order of magnitude, ensure equity, and strengthen national security. Diplomacy needs to be very **nimble** and **agile** to tap opportunities in technology. Look at AI today. The big challenge is how you exploit opportunity without compromising on risk.

The civil servant of today has to **grapple** with all this. Imagine a young district magistrate dealing with drinking water issues, unfulfilled **grievances**, bridge construction, and AI simultaneously. They operate in such a way that they can hop from the Ministry of Commerce to the Ministry of Defense. They have to be virtual **polymaths**.

The UPSC tries to select candidates with these wide-ranging attributes. The exams make sure you are informed, but that information also has to become knowledge, and that knowledge must convert into **wisdom**. As the Prime Minister said, it has to be public service, not just public office.

Niharika Bummania: Many thanks, Lt. General Raj Shukla, for joining us on today's episode. It's been a wonderful conversation.

Akashvani: You were listening to a discussion on UPSC at 100: A century of merit, integrity, and public service. This program was produced and presented by the News Services Division of Akashvani.

Vocabulary Guide Available

A fully alphabetized vocabulary table detailing all the highlighted CEFR B1, B2, C1, and C2 words—including English meanings, Hindi translations, and example sentences—is provided in the accompanying Vocabulary Document.